

By Kate King

June 8, 2026 5:30 am ET

Vancouver, British Columbia, is one of the World Cup host cities. BOB FRID/EPA/SHUTTERSTOCK

Quick Summary



- Hotel bookings in U.S. World Cup host cities lag behind Canada and Mexico, with San Francisco the only U.S. city to crack that threshold at 44%.

View more

The World Cup starts later this week. U.S. hotels are already in last place.

Hotel bookings in Canada and Mexico are outpacing all but one American city ahead of FIFA's biggest soccer competition, which is unfolding across 16 North American cities starting Thursday.

Vancouver and Guadalajara boast the top occupancy rates at 48%, according to CoStar. Toronto, Mexico City and Monterrey, Mexico, are also more than 40%-booked. San Francisco is the only U.S. city to crack that threshold at 44%.

The data firm analyzed hotel business in 14 of the 16 host cities ahead of the games.

Some U.S. hotel owners say they are getting decent rates. But the foreign host cities hold a number of advantages over their American counterparts, including often more rabid soccer fans and overall affordability.

Tickets to this year's World Cup games in the U.S. reached record-high prices, with dozens of tickets to the final match already selling for more than \$20,000 a seat, according to resale tracker TicketData. Transportation costs also soared.

"When it got down to pricing and being able to make those decisions, there were a lot of aspirational travelers who were probably shut out of the marketplace," said Dave Guenther, president of luxury sports travel company Roadtrips.

A sculpture in Mexico City. YURI CORTEZ/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

Monterrey stadium in Mexico. DANIEL BECERRIL/REUTERS

Visa concerns and the U.S. political climate that many foreigners perceive as unwelcoming also dissuaded some international soccer enthusiasts from traveling to the U.S.

The disappointing performance by hotels in U.S. host cities reflects a lost opportunity to boost local economies as much as anticipated. Cities have spent hundreds of millions of dollars related to this once-in-a-generation sporting event. Major investments range from security and stadium upgrades to transit improvements and marketing.

Even though ticket prices for the games can be higher in Mexico, Guenther has had plenty of success south of the border. Demand for travel packages to Mexico City, where Roadtrips is working with five hotels including the Four Seasons, has been strong, which he attributed in large part to Latin American fans traveling there.

Short-term rentals in Mexico are also enjoying a significant boost. Guest demand growth for Mexican properties was pacing far higher, as of May 26, than other markets on the two nights around matches, according to data tracker AirDNA.

Price is likely a big driver. Short-term rentals in Mexico are booking at far lower rates than American and Canadian cities, with nightly rates around \$100 depending on the city compared with around \$300 a night in Kansas City, Mo., Boston and Miami.

“Those cheap budget places are going first and fastest,” said Bram Gallagher, director of economics and forecasting at AirDNA.

Toronto’s BMO Field, which will host six matches, is located downtown, making it an easy trek from nearby hotels. The city is increasing public

transit to the stadium on match days but keeping subway, bus and streetcar prices at normal levels of less than \$4 a ride.

Toronto City Hall. KEVIN SOUSA/IMAGN IMAGES/REUTERS

In the New York region, by contrast, public-transit officials initially set round-trip train ticket prices at \$150 for a ride from Manhattan to MetLife Stadium in New Jersey. The price has since been lowered to \$98, still far above the \$12.90 cost for National Football League game days. New York, which is hosting eight games including the championship final on July 19, is 39% booked.

Traveler concerns about getting through customs at American airports are deterring some visitors, hotel owners said.

“I think the media stories surrounding people who’ve been detained haven’t helped,” said Jon Bortz, chief executive of Pebblebrook Hotel Trust.

Pebblebrook, which has hotels in four U.S. World Cup markets, is expecting a modest boost in business from the matches. Room rates at the company’s Miami property, for example, are up about 9% compared with a typical June.

Occupancy is flat, he said, because the World Cup has so far largely displaced other business he typically counts on during the summer weeks. But the soccer tournament has driven fewer bookings than the World Baseball Classic held in the city earlier this year, Bortz said.

Some hotel owners are still counting on last-minute bookings closer to game day. CoStar’s analysis looked at bookings on the two nights surrounding World Cup matches, as of June 1.

Host Hotels & Resorts, which has properties in 10 U.S. World Cup markets, is already seeing a 38% jump in average daily rates from transient travelers for the tournament period.

“If you look at some historical booking patterns, up to 40% of bookings materialize within 0 to 6 days before the match,” said CEO Jim Risoleo.

Appeared in the June 10, 2026, print edition as 'U.S. Trails in World Cup Hotel Match'.

[Kate King](#) covers New York City real estate for The Wall Street Journal and writes frequently about how remote work affects the city's office districts, businesses and neighborhoods. She also writes about retail real estate nationally, with a particular focus on the evolution of in-person and online...



Videos



**Why This Hospitality
Mogul Thinks Intellectual
Property is King**

**Emily Blunt on Her Most
Iconic Line, 'Disclosure
Day' and More**

**Olipop: The Modern
Version of Soda**

WSJ | Buy Side

Reviews and recommendations, independent of The Wall Street Journal newsroom.

GIFT GUIDES

The Best Father's Day Gifts for Every Type of Dad

STUDENT LOANS

Best Private Student Loans in June 2026

AUTO INSURANCE

Cheap Full Coverage Car Insurance in 2026

LIFE INSURANCE

High-Net-Worth Life Insurance: Strategies for Wealthy Individuals and Families

BANKING

How Much Money Can You Make Chasing High-Yield Savings Rates?

FINANCIAL ADVISORS

5 of the Top Financial Advisor Companies for Retirees: Well-Known Fiduciary Firms to Consider